FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The four assembly elections to be held in April 2026, the results of which will be announced on May 4, hold a significance for the ruling BJP at the Centre that would seem disproportionate to their geography. For the BJP, these are not just state contests but tests of national expansion into regions where its footprint remains uneven. Between Assam, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Kerala, the BJP has seen power only in the first, and even that only for a decade. Although they made significant inroads in Bengal in the 2021 state election, winning 77 seats in the 294-member assembly compared to just three in 2016, these states still remain, in varying degrees, alien terrain: shaped by political cultures that have historically resisted the ideology of the BJP. Breaching these Opposition bastions, therefore, has long been on the BJP's radar. Whether status quo prevails or not will be crucial to shaping perceptions and future outcomes. It will determine the extent to which India's ruling party can shrug off the taint of being essentially a 'North Indian' party. This is its last chance to refashion itself thus before the 2029 general election, since the state polls that remain will revert to home turf.

The symbolism is equally laden with national consequences for the Opposition. Take West Bengal, the state drawing the most attention with the BJP's high-octane battle with Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress (TMC). If beating Mamata will open up Bengal's critical cache of 42 Lok Sabha seats for the BJP in 2029, saving her citadel against the saffron onslaught will elevate the feisty 71-year-old as one of the most formidable Opposition leaders nationally. A fourth consecutive victory would put her in a league of rare political durability, especially after she has defeated the mighty BJP. The southern arena carries its own strategic implications. The Congress sees Kerala as vital to its narrative. A win would give it power in three southern states, with the possibility of influence in a fourth if M.K. Stalin's DMK retains Tamil Nadu. For the BJP, this would be a dangerous development, with the potential for an Opposition consolidation in a region where it is seeking to establish a foothold. There would be an urgent need for it to especially torpedo the Congress's chances as it competes with it in the national political space.

At the ground level, these elections take on a more personal dimension. Four powerful regional leaders dominate their respective states, each confronting a moment that would define their political future. For them, a whole era of dominance is at stake. We are calling it the 'Battle of the Chieftains'. Himanta Biswa Sarma of Assam is the only BJP face in the mix. He has had a firm grip on Assam's polity for over 20 years but enters his first election as an incumbent chief minister. Proving his winnability is vital for the 57-year-old's larger ambitions, and he's going for it with both strategy and rhetoric fully loaded. In Bengal, incumbency perhaps weighs heavier for Mamata after 15 years in power. She has headed off the BJP in two tense assembly elections before, but this third time she may be most in need of luck.



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In Tamil Nadu, Stalin presents a steelier picture on the face of it, guarding an ideological territory hitherto inimical to the BJP. But the 73-year-old chief minister is not fully beyond peril. His term has created enough anti-incumbency for the DMK's traditional rival, the BJP-backed AIADMK, to spot a chance. Also, actor Vijay, with his political startup Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), brings an unpredictable third element to a bipolar state. In Kerala, Left veteran Pinarayi Vijayan is looking for a last hurrah at age 80, but after a decade's rule, he may have erred in not anointing a successor. The Congress showed solid gains in recent local body polls, though the party excels in producing many slips between the lip and prospective cups of joy, especially through factionalism. The irony is that both sides increasingly accuse the other of being "the B-team of the BJP".

Two broader currents cut across these elections. One is the contentious Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of voter rolls. Bengal is where it threatens to affect the outcome most controversially. The first round of clean-up saw 6.3 million names deleted. Adjudication on another 6 million, according to latest reports, is logging 45 per cent deletions, with 1.1 million names still in process. The TMC claims many of those deleted are in Muslim-dominated seats, which comprise Mamata's base. She frames this as a battle for Bengal's identity, even making a dramatic appearance in the Supreme Court to argue the case. In Assam, where such revision was not undertaken, the 2023 delimitation exercise had already reshaped the electoral map, reducing Muslim-dominated seats from 36 to 22 in a 126-seat assembly.

The second issue is the growing trend of welfare politics. None of the chieftains are untouched by anti-incumbency. Each, therefore, relies heavily on targeted welfare schemes, with a particular focus on women voters. They are now among the most decisive electoral constituencies.

This cover story brings together the larger narratives, the strengths and weaknesses, and the data that underpins them all. It will help you track what may be one of India's most consequential elections before 2029.

(Aroon Purie)